

The Observer

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CREATING A VIABLE TOWN CENTER AN IMPATIENT PLEA

And Walt [Disney] was right! Through the postwar decades Americans happily allowed their towns to be destroyed. They'd flock to Disneyland at Anaheim, or later to Disney World in Florida, and walk down Main Street, and think, gee, it feels good here. Then they'd go back home and tear down half the old buildings downtown and pave them over for parking lots, throw a parade to celebrate a new K Mart opening—even when it put ten local merchants out of business—turn Elm Street into a six-lane crosstown expressway, pass zoning laws that forbade corner grocery stores in residential neighborhoods and setback rules that required every new business to locate on a one-acre lot until things became so spread out you had to drive everywhere. They'd build the new central school four miles out of town on a busy highway so that kids couldn't walk there. They'd do every fool thing possible to destroy good existing relationships between things in their towns, and put their local economies at the mercy of distant corporations whose officers didn't give a damn whether these towns lived or died. And then, when vacation time rolled around, they'd flock back to Disney World to feel good about America.

James Howard Kunstler
(*The Geography of Nowhere*)

No one better captures—and so acerbically—the “rise and decline of America’s man-made landscape” as does Jim Kunstler. His descriptions of decaying towns and cities apply universally and seem particularly apropos of Marysville, Lake Stevens, Monroe, and most other Snohomish County burgs.

On his Web site (www.kunstler.com) Kunstler includes a kind of photo-of-the-week section, which depicts an egregiously ugly suburban totem, decrepit building, or abandoned landscape. If one offers to add to his collection, Kunstler responds with a polite “thank you” and a note that visually chronicling Americans’ collective embrace of garish kitsch provides him a source of limitless personal entertainment.

Occasionally, you will find a pathetic example of Marysville’s desuetude on the back pages of *The Observer*: a “welcoming” sign with its letters partially eroded; the city’s beloved water tower—which hasn’t been used in decades; the mall’s barren concrete wall that serves as the appropriate counterpoise to Ebey Slough, really an unnavigable mudflat; or freeway-sized downtown streets paved with acres of asphalt—they’re posted at

25 mph, but one could safely cruise them at 60.¹

A few years ago, I reluctantly and hesitantly ran for city council on the threat to revitalize downtown. Employing the typical campaign hyperbole, more suitable for driving dolts than thoughtful citizens, I suggested to voters that it was “time for a change.” And wouldn’t it be nice to create a vibrant, attractive, mixed-use center to magnetize the people, give the city an identifiable core, and support locally owned businesses? Well, no, the people said. We prefer to retain the scowling gas bag, Shirley Bartholomew, who would sooner rid the city of “bums” and

prevent bare-nekkid ladies from dancing in front of inebriated mill workers than lend her support to a serious revitalization effort.

Despite my cynical disposition toward the city, the mayor nevertheless invited me to join a new, council-sanctioned group, the Downtown Revitalization Committee. For months of meetings I had understood that we were supposed to focus on revitalizing downtown. How silly of me. Over time the committee would become the catch basin for several previously hatched projects, none

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Excursions

TO GORE OR NOT TO GORE?

It troubles me that this great and terribly flawed country manages to select such mediocre men to occupy its highest office. A few presidents you could not trust to be alone with your children. Others had no compunction about sending American boys off to their deaths. One loved the bomb, and used it twice to destroy entire cities and their inhabitants. Another was forced to resign for crimes against the people. A former actor circumvented the law in running paramilitary operations to pursue his personal foreign policy agenda.

This year is no different. We are presented with two middle-aged men who represent the worst aspects of our country's moral climate.

One, a Texan and privileged son of a former president, exudes

"charm" and "sociability." While overseeing the world's busiest death machine, his stubborn refusal to admit the obvious—that the criminal justice system doesn't work— earns high marks for his "leadership." As president, he would step up assistance to his rich benefactors and further screw the poor. He likes the military, guns, lower taxes, and school vouchers. It is in education that he claims to have achieved the most, although the evidence provides a very different story.

On the Democrat side, we have Vice President Al Gore, who seems completely befuddled by almost everything. Perhaps his biggest challenge is overcoming the legacy of his current boss, whose peccadilloes, real and imagined, continue to nip at Gore's boots. But he, too, would lavish more money on the Pentagon and penalize the poor. He has supported the NRA, favors welfare reform, and confuses prayer services with fund-raisers.

Gore slips badly by failing to appreciate the country's apparent willingness to seriously reconsider the death penalty. It is his opponent, after all, who blithely maintains that only guilty Texans dies in a state made famous by its gritty frontier manners, loose affection for the law, incompetent public defenders, and deep history of political nepotism and good-ole-boy networks. But the VP can only say "me, too" when asked for his views on state-sponsored murder.

Yet, there is one issue that looms larger than any other, in terms of the power of the presidency. And that's selecting Supreme Court justices. Here is

where we should focus our attention.

This is a divided court, with many hugely significant cases being decided on 5-4 votes. Rehnquist, who is 75, will likely retire during the next four years. Stevens, appointed by Ford but the most liberal of the nine jurists, is 80. O'Connor has hinted that she may depart soon. Just one change can affect the outcome in a host of important decisions for years to come.

Who occupies the White House next January will probably make a huge difference in the fate of unionism, abortion, privacy, and civil rights (especially affirmative action). A Gore presidency combined with a new Democratic Senate could restore the liberal direction of the Warren Court. If Bush gets elected and the Republicans retain control of the Senate, we can look forward to extremely conservative rulings dominated by Scalia, achieved by even bigger margins than today.

Is the Supreme Court enough for progressives to eschew Nader in a nose-plugging vote for Gore?

My initial attempt to answer my own question led me to a wait-and-see approach, given the several months ahead before the November election. This amounted to an intellectual cop-out, I believe. Gore is Gore, and he's had so many years in office and shaking down political paymasters that we have a pretty good idea of what makes the Vice President tick.

But neither Gore nor the current occupant of the Oval Office has uttered a progressive word,

save for the sake of political expediency. In Clinton's case, delving beneath his ideological skin leads quickly to a mindless exercise in electoral gamesmanship, a practical guide to winning elections by reading polls, preempting opponents' positions, feigning sincerity, and, above all, prostituting one's self—better known as "fund-raising."

Then I listened to and watched Ralph Nader's acceptance speech before the Green Party's national convention. (www.cspan.org/campaign2000/greenparty.asp) He said:

- Community and self-improvement are mutually reinforcing.
- Out of an informed, motivated, and mobilized people will come the justice that spells genuine prosperity and the broader fulfillment of human possibilities [on his Web site, www.votenader.org]

It's time, he said, to employ "the people's yardsticks" to decisions by corporations, governments, and the courts. He cited a myriad of repulsive statistics to illustrate the problems with favoring corporatism: America's 200 richest people control more wealth than the poorest three billion world inhabitants; the average American CEO makes 416 times as much money per year as his or her average employee;

I will vote for Nader in November—with no hesitation.

The Observer

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of which had the remotest connection to building a vibrant, attractive, mixed-use center. Our dwindling membership was commanded to “provide input” on repaving State Ave., deciding whether parking on Third St. should be parallel or angled, and determining the number of stalls for the motorized boat launch on Ebey Slough.

But in the beginning, during the first several months of biweekly meetings we agreed that our goal was to submit a plan to the voters at the next year’s general election. (I had urged the development of a *master plan*. More on this later.) We began our deliberations in July 1998. So our target date was November 1999. We missed it—and then some.

Despite the efforts of an experienced professional facilitator, it took our committee, originally an aggregation of eighteen disparate souls, the better part of 1998 to determine the boundaries of downtown! At first glance, that may seem ridiculous. But on further reflection, you’re likely to sympathize. With the exception of Everett, Edmonds, and Snohomish, it is difficult to recognize the downtowns of any of our

county’s cities. Quick. Where is Lynnwood’s downtown? Stanwood features a block or two that could pass as a downtown. The same holds true for Arlington. Guided more by nostalgia than vision, our committee seemed unable to move beyond the half-block of Third St. in its attempts to define Marysville’s hub. And there the matter stuck in our goo-like brains (our meetings began at seven in the morning), possibly with mental photographs of the Dutch Bakery, Davis Stationery, Hilton Pharmacy, and Carr’s Hardware representing vague notions of downtown.

Also, there is really no center, or urban core, that is in any way *down*. Geographical directions seem tragically inadequate in locating what used to be the vital commercial and social nexus of these old communities. Beginning in the late seventies, Marysville’s landscape underwent a dramatic change. First K-Mart erected one of its huge stores about three miles north of Third St. Within a year or two, Fred Meyer constructed an even larger structure, a behemoth that more closely resembles a Midwestern field house than a place to buy a loaf of bread or a pair of socks. These essentially prefabricated monstrosities—replete with huge, obtrusive neon signs—are surrounded by acres of parking lot, what Kunstler calls ‘asphalt lagoons.’ They are far removed from residential areas; so people have to drive their cars to get there. And when they do, Fred Meyer and K-Mart hope that shoppers depart with their SUVs loaded with cheap, tacky merchandise assembled in distant sweatshops.

THE ELUSIVE MASTER PLAN

Why is a master plan so important for the eventual success of a revitalization effort? Here is what New Urbanists Andre Duany, Elizabeth Plater-Zyberk, and Jeff Speck write in



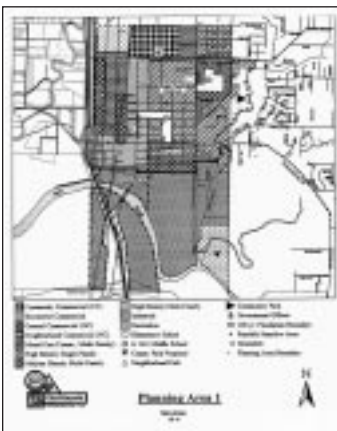
Marysville's Downtown

their recent book *Suburban Nation*:

If the city is to compete against the suburb, someone must play the role of the master developer, and in most cases this someone can only be the city government itself...The city can best achieve true predictability by replacing its zoning ordinances with a physical plan, one with as much precision as that of a new office park, in which every projected building is given shape. This plan must be created through a public process in which citizens participate with the understanding that the outcome will become the law. Once completed and enacted, this plan will control future growth, such

that potential developers know exactly what they can build and when they can start construction...

...There are many benefits to creating a physically prescriptive master plan for a city, not the least of which is that it allows government to return to the business of governing. Currently, city commission agendas are overwhelmed by a disproportionate number of contests over individual real estate projects, as if real estate were more important than schooling, public safety, economic development or quality of life.² These battles are fought precisely



Marysville's Comprehensive Plan
Downtown area

Continued next page

because there is no master plan in place to guide development. Completing and enacting a new city master plan can often seem like a war, but isn't it better to wage one big war and get it over with, rather than fighting new battles every week?

When I argued for a master plan, the city's assistant planner, an occasional participant in our early morning table-chats, said that the city "already had a plan." And what might that be? I asked. "The comprehensive plan," he said.

Have you ever looked at a city's comprehensive plan? Typically, it will include a series of maps and overlays, with each area in the city outlined or colored to reflect varying zoning patterns. The "downtown" area may be shaded brown, say, to indicate a certain building density and allowance for commercial properties. The corresponding code, almost always in text format, sets out prescribed parking requirements, height restrictions, sidewalk widths, and the like.

No comprehensive plan that I've seen can even vaguely qualify

as a *master* plan of the sort described by Duany et al. There is no attempt in a comp-plan to provide a visual sense of what a fully developed area is supposed to look like. These plans do not include landscaping, streetscapes, or design elements. It would be impossible to construct, let alone visualize, a three-dimensional model of an area from a typical comprehensive plan.

Instead, individual developers propose separate, unrelated projects that the city planners study and ultimately alter—sometimes significantly. At all times the planners keep the city code book close at hand to point out all of a project's potential violations.³ In the end, provided the economics favor development activity, the myriad projects created by different builders and faraway architects resemble a hodgepodge of disparate styles and uses, none of which fit together. The resulting product—what we see in Marysville and elsewhere throughout the county—constitutes "an ugly, dysfunctional burg," replete with proliferating curb cuts, aesthetic disharmonies, strip malls, asphalt lagoons, and cars, cars, cars.

Developing master plans

requires money and commitment. The city council provided neither. When I asked one morning what the city council expected, given its lack of support, one of the two council members assigned to the committee replied, "A miracle." Another committee member, a local business owner, suggested that the committee was formed to keep a few people busy; it was never expected to succeed.

DESTROYING WHAT WAS—IN THE NAME OF MODERNIZATION AND PROSPERITY

So, why do we permit such assaults on the physical and natural landscapes? Why do K-Marts, Dairy Queens, and Home Depots sprout overnight while locally owned businesses that have survived for decades call it quits? Well, golly gee, that's progress for you.

And progress is what it's all about, we are told. The mayor's mantra is "growth equals prosperity." He arrives at his pleasant-sounding but patently false formulation through a couple of routes.

The first involves the nature of Marysville's development, which is largely dominated by tract after tract of single-family houses. These new homes, even the mayor concedes, contribute only eighty percent of the costs they impose on the various infrastructures, including schools. Rather than increase impact fees so that the revenues balance costs, the mayor instead puts on his economic development hat in hopes of wooing financially promising commercial enterprises. The idea is to have the taxes generated by these businesses offset the shortfalls created by each new single-family dwelling.

As I've written before in these pages, commercial growth brings to an area even more people who need housing. Everett's navy base,

as its boosters expected, brought only a few boats but lots of federal dollars to stimulate economic activity. More people making more money translates into more houses, more cars, more congested roadways, more overcrowded classrooms, more pollution, and less open space. From 1970 to 1990, Puget Sound's rate of land development exceeded population growth by two and half times. That means decreasing density (people per square mile) over time.⁴

The second path, of course, gets right down to why this and almost any other mayor sits in office. He must ultimately come through for those few individuals who paid for his election. These are the generally inconspicuous folks of quiet, patient capital who own property and have shares in—if not also own—the local banks. They desire to parlay their holdings into mini-fortunes of the old-fashioned kind. Increased mitigation fees charged against housing tracts eat into their profit margins. That's a no-no in the incestuous politics that governs wannabe growth-centers like Marysville.⁵

THE WAY WE WERE

Chapter 15 of the city's centennial *Pictorial History* is entitled "The Growth Years." Therein the authors take the reader through a series of events that chronicle the city's destruction. But there is no hint of regret and clearly no recognition of how the accumulation of these seemingly innocuous occurrences led to the creation of the present-day "ugly, dysfunctional burg." Here are a few excerpts:

The once fertile farming fields now yielded a crop of small, low cost houses for the young workers coming into the work force.



The SW corner of State Ave. and First St.

Site of proposed boat launch

Suddenly[?] Marysville began to hear references to being a bedroom community.

O'Neil's General Store, once the scene of so many Saturday night dances, was razed to make way for other small businesses. Many of the mom and pop businesses gave way to the larger chain stores, fast food restaurants and gas stations.



Growth—wildly unpredictable growth [sic] seized Marysville in the decade of the '80s. Suddenly [again?] Marysville was a secret discovered by the rest of the country [sic]...The community in general offered the stability of generations of citizens with *the foresight of a city council that was willing to stretch their [sic] imagination to encompass a more urban future* [added emphasis].

Aside from its puerile prose, the last paragraph speaks volumes about the entrenched problem of Marysville: Successive city councils have demonstrated all the foresight of a hungry fish swallowing a hooked worm. In their zeal to usher in "modernization," the councils stretched their collective imagination as far as the next round of tax revenues and campaign contributions. The "urban future" they may have envisaged turned into nothing more than

bland, auto-dependent sprawl and destroyed the elements that defined a close-knit community enjoyed by previous generations of inhabitants.

Growth produced a lot of changes in the landscape. If a building wasn't coming down, it was moving, or another was being raised from the rubble [sic] of its former occupant.

It was bound to happen sooner or later—businesses at the north end of Marysville were about to boom. From the earliest days of Marysville up through the 1950s, the entire business life of Marysville centered around the first four streets of town...

Becoming proprietors in 1949, Ed and Mary Davis operated the ice cream parlor, the second door down from the corner of Third and State, for almost 14 years. [Today, one has to drive to the north end of town to purchase an ice cream cone from the usual suspect—B & R.]

Marysville High School stood for 60 years as a tribute to higher education in Marysville...[it] was constructed at the cost of \$60,000, and was often referred to as the most magnificent of such buildings. [A beautiful, four-story structure, it also succumbed to modernization's wrecking ball. For the last three decades, Marysville's secondary students have experienced an exquisite sense of community. They have been attending classes in the

state's largest high school, a vast, sprawling agglomeration of single-story buildings accessible only by car and bus.]

Marysville had to make a decision at the end of the '80s. The option of remaining a village had swept past long ago. Now the choices were a town or a city—which one? As it happened, the decision was really not that of the community of Marysville. The Navy announced that they would place a Home Port in Everett....Marysville would become an obvious choice for the many families that would be moving here.

The "pictorial history" refrains from stating a genuinely obvious fact: the city's elected officials lobbied extremely hard for Scoop Jackson's legacy; they were not passive bystanders.

Critics of the homeport, whom Everett mayor Bill Moore routinely called 'communists,' foresaw the growth-inducing impacts of the base. The families pouring into Marysville from naval ships and elsewhere were ushered into newly constructed single-family homes that oozed up the denuded hillsides. From there, mothers and fathers would trek to K-Mart and Fred Meyer, almost completely ignoring what little downtown remained in the



Old Marysville High School
Destroyed in the name of progress

wake of stretched imaginations.

Revitalizing sprawl-wrecked "downtowns" is made even more difficult by the lack of real-life models. Yes, Seattle has a downtown, but its scale overwhelms the suburban mind. Portland has paid even more attention to creating a pedestrian-friendly urban center. But these are major cities with hundreds of thousands of inhabitants. For much smaller towns like Marysville, another model is required.

COMMUNITY BEFORE FAMILY

Anthropological evidence is somewhat sketchy, but it seems clear that the oldest human institution is not the family, as is popularly thought, but the community...

In fact, it is reasonable to assume, as most anthropologists do nowadays, that it was some form of community living that made humans "human." In other words, it was not until some group of hominids meeting around some water hole began grunting and jabbering at each other in regular ways that speech developed, and those groups in which speech was most successful...were the ones that were more likely to survive.

— Kirkpatrick Sale
Human Scale

The New Urbanists, a rapidly expanding segment of the architectural community, envisions resurrected Main Streets. For the first half of its life, Marysville had a "Main Street" appeal, with its ice cream parlor, bakery, stationery store, pharmacy, and a handful of restaurants. These businesses were all locally owned and managed. They served a small population that lived within

walking distance.

But in the name of progress, most of the structures were demolished. "Big is beautiful" turned E.F. Schumacher's prescription on its head. The surviving buildings and the real estate upon which they sit have been purchased by people who live elsewhere, some as far away as Southeastern Canada. From their distant repose, these absentee landlords consider Marysville's fortunes only in terms of their own. In place of bulldozed property, the Marysville Town Center emerged as a nose-thumbing gesture to Schumacher and the human soul.

THE TOWN "CENTER"

What the foresighted city councilors failed to grasp, as they literally paved the way for impersonal modernization, is the importance of both human scale and integration. Bigger is not better. People need to feel a part of a smaller, manageable whole in which they determine their own social, economic, and political arrangements. But the people's interests were sold to the highest bidder.

Two decades ago, however, the city came close to creating a more authentic town center than the

current "barren boomerang."⁶ The council established a Downtown Redevelopment Agency, which had far-reaching authority under state and federal laws. The council could declare its "downtown" a blighted zone, condemn property, and receive special financing to redevelop the area of several acres, bounded by State Ave., Fourth St., the railroad tracks, and First St. (At the time, many of the homes and businesses had long been abandoned, leaving a cluster of dilapidated, boarded-up buildings.) The agency hired a consultant to devise a master plan, which featured a cluster of mixed-use, multi-storied buildings, a focal point (an aesthetically pleasing monolith rather than an abandoned water tower), clearly marked and attractive walkways, and an opening to the waterfront.

The consultant's plan was accepted by the agency, then approved by both the planning commission and the city council. But, after consistently praising the project's initial development and characterizing it as the new "heart" of the city, then-Mayor Daryl Brennick vetoed the entire project citing "property rights."

Like a hideous Phoenix rising



One of Marysville's asphalt lagoons

The "barren boomerang" forms a backdrop.

from the ashes of this awful decision, the barren boomerang emerged as Plan B to give new meaning to the term 'blight.' Instead of opening to the waterfront, the mall features a huge blank wall, essentially undermining any future attempts to integrate retail and recreational activities. As one drives west on Third St., the last vestige of Marysville's downtown, one sees on the horizon, not an attractive work of art, but an oversized American flag atop a giant metal pole. While the originally conceived town center put pedestrians first, the barren boomerang worships the car. And while even Lynnwood had the presence of mind to require Alderwood Mall developers to plant trees in and around their parking lots, the Marysville city council members of stretched imagination allowed Plan B to materialize with no landscaping whatsoever. Take away the cars and one could congregate the entire cast of World War II on the huge expanse of asphalt that dwarfs the handful of chain stores.

STARTING OVER

Its predecessors having given birth to one abomination (the barren boomerang), a new crop of city councilors apparently thought

about taking another stab at revitalizing downtown, wherever that might be. They directed the mayor to form a committee of his choosing. But they neglected to establish a charter for or otherwise give any direction to the group that in some vague sense was supposed to "revitalize downtown." The council said "go forth" but never said when the committee should return nor with what. As a token of its support, the council set aside thirty thousand dollars, but denied the committee authority to spend it.

With one exception: the mayor hired a consultant at \$750 a day. Since the committee was to meet twice a month, the consultant's fee alone could consume the entire budget in less than two years. I say 'could,' because the committee members, sensing the glacial pace of their efforts, thought they could do no worse in facilitating their own meetings. So, we put the consultant's services on hold.

By the time I left the committee, after 18 months, the group had dwindled to a mere handful of members. No one was left from the business community (originally, there had been representatives from the Chamber and Rotary), the school district's envoy appeared only rarely, as did



the assistant city planner, and the Tribes seldom sent an emissary. We reduced our meetings to one a month and had tried to create subcommittees to explore different aspects of "revitalization."

LESSONS LEARNED

Revitalizing a moribund downtown—or, in Marysville's case, attempting to find it—constitutes a significant challenge, especially to a collection of individuals with no specific charter, expertise, or resources. At nearly every meeting we had before us a long, thin aerial photograph of the city with State Ave. running down the center. The picture stretched from the mudflats at the bottom to Grove St. at the top, and from the freeway to 47th. But rather than helping, the photograph eventually became an irritating reminder of just how bad things had gotten in this once simple town. How can we or anyone else transform this ugly tossed-salad of mostly decrepit buildings, scattered empty lots, scrawny sidewalks, and acres of asphalt? Where do we begin?

In my judgment we lacked focus. We all shared this gnawing appreciation of where we and the city were; but we failed to spend enough time trying to figure out the goal. At what point could we say that we were "finished"?

To be sure, the facilitator had managed to squeeze out a "mission statement," the first and

often the only accomplishment of committees with no franchise. We agreed—after a few months of meetings—that we all wanted an environmentally friendly, pedestrian-oriented, mixed-use, village-like downtown where people would live, work, and play. Splendid.

What would this look like? How could we sell the voters on the idea without a clear depiction, preferably a drawing or three-dimensional model? But my suggestion for a master plan lay figuratively in the corner of the room for months as the mayor shoved several unrelated tasks in front of us.

The motorized boat launch project was met with all the grace and candor that one extends to unknown distant cousins announcing their intention to move in for the summer. The whole summer? Really. All but one of us abhorred the concept. It would undermine efforts to develop a future waterfront. It would occupy too much space for the number of people it served. The one committee member, a boat owner, who liked the project insisted that people who use boats spend money, too. So we'll make sure someone erects a bait shop and place to buy beer.

Then we discovered that the city council had approved contracts for re-paving State Ave. Included in the council's action was the formation of a "task force" to gather citizen input and make recommendations. So, at the

"suggestion" of the mayor, our revitalization committee was quickly converted to a task force to study channelization, on-street parking, and light standards. Several members seemed eager to embed a metal strawberry in the center of the city's major intersection (4th and State).

I suggested that there were two basic re-paving options. If we ever got serious about creating a revitalized downtown along the lines of what we had described in the nearly forgotten mission statement, motorists might be inclined to pay attention to what's outside their cars as they drove north along State Ave. In that case, we should emphasize aesthetics over transportation efficiency. On the other hand, if things remain pretty much as they are, with an unmodified barren boomerang on the left and the discount cigarette shop to the right, perhaps we should do drivers a favor by creating as many travel lanes as possible to speed them through "downtown."

You can guess which option will be pursued. The council, oblivious to the irony of their choices, voted to maximize the number of lanes.

ONCE THERE WERE GREENFIELDS

I cannot hide my profound cynicism. Yet, I cannot emphasize too much the importance of creating a vibrant, economically viable downtown to arrest the centrifugal forces of sprawl and preserve what's left of farmlands and the natural environment. Ladies and gentlemen, more SUVs and housing tracts do not a community make. People must move closer together—and that goes for those comfortably ensconced in their House Beautiful homes on wooded five-acre lots.

But our biggest little secret as

suburban Americans is that we have come to loathe one another. We cannot possibly imagine living next door to or beneath another human being.

Rather, we have come to worship tiny worlds of orthogonal cleanliness typified by the well-maintained, garage-dominated suburban tract house with manicured front lawn (heavily fertilized, of course) and frequently washed and vacuumed sport utility vehicles parked in front. (This fairly describes some of my neighbors. Others seem not to care for maintaining their private landscapes.)

Suburbia is a very expensive way to live, both personally and societally. Each vehicle, for example, costs a household about \$6,000 a year in payments, gas, insurance, depreciation, and general upkeep. At an hourly rate of \$20, we would devote 300 hours a year of our working lives to pay for our car.

Many, if not most, suburban housing tracts feature "quiet cul-de-sacs," which bottle-up residents, create congested traffic nodes, and prevent anyone from simply driving through the neighborhood. It is not unusual for motorists unfamiliar with the terrain to get lost trying to make their way out of suburban mazes. From these protected enclaves, no one would think to walk anywhere, except for exercise. A more purposeful jaunt would be dangerous, awkward, and ultimately exhausting, because there is no place to go. Nor are we in the habit of spending an hour or so pounding the pavement to fetch provisions from the closest store, which might be miles away.

OBLIGATORY DIATRIBE

Individually, we may count geniuses among us. But collectively we have demonstrated profound stupidity by allowing



Barracks-like apartments

Keeping the riffraff out of "good" neighborhoods

myopic moneyed interested to dictate how we should live.

Let's start with contrasts. Most of the world's population barely has a roof over its head at night, scant food to eat, and no pot in which to pee. Their lives are truly nasty, brutish, and short. What little incomes they receive have fallen in real dollars over the last few decades. In the U.S., to whose flag so many of us proudly pledge allegiance and whose corporate stocks we feverishly purchase, one out of five children lives in deep poverty and their government continues to invest more in its weapons than in its people. As John Kenneth Galbraith described us, we have become a culture of contentment, having lost the capacity to care.

Against this backdrop of extreme wealth and poverty, we passively live lives of depraved indifference, seeking the comforts of a global economy that further rewards the prosperous few at the expense of the restless many. Writ small, we have unwittingly conspired to place our local public realms at the disposal of conservative idiots, Republicans, traffic engineers, unscrupulous developers, and compliant politicians. Indeed, we have retreated into our private worlds to such an extent that we have long since forgotten the necessary patterns of a viable commonweal. If we find community at all, it is apt to be in church, on a soccer field, or in Moose halls—but never in public places. There are none. We have made sure of this.

During a candidates forum a few years back, an audience member accused me of wanting to pack everyone on top of each other. I suspect that she had in mind images of awful barracks-like apartment complexes to which we consign society's poor and desperate. She, the self-satisfied wife of a former county coun-

cil member, was clearly not about to share space with riffraff. Rather, she insinuated, they should be in ghettos set off from the "good" people who fear God, work hard, and invest wisely.

We have a problem in this country. As much as some of us might want to cram contented Americans into ugly wooden barracks and give the poor dominion over our elite's palatial estates, we continue to insist—although I don't know why—that we are a democracy in which disputes are resolved by voting rather than government-enforced compliance. But for all the triumphal rhetoric about a nation of immigrants melting in a collaborative pot, we relish both uniformity and separation. We have little tolerance for those who differ from us in any respect, from the color of our skin to the size of the vehicles we drive; "they" belong somewhere else, preferably out of sight.

So the task of bringing disparate people together is not an easy one, especially after decades of sprawl and increasing cultural contentment. It is much easier to be selfish and consume than to care about each other, the places we live, and the environment we inhabit.

ENDNOTES

¹ A visitor to Marysville's city hall entrance lobby will confront a series of photographs on the wall. These show in successive frames the bringing down of the water tower that used to be located in the area now dominated by what I've called "the barren boomerang," the city's L-shaped mall. (See endnote 6 below.)

² Recently, scores of angry citizens virtually stormed city gates to chal-

lenge a project proposed by Belmark Industries, one of the larger homebuilders in the area. The project included a gas station, a 7/11-like convenience store, dozens of apartments, a park-and-ride lot, and other "neighborhood commercial" outlets. There were severe problems with the project, not the least of which is that it would have necessitated a change in the city's comprehensive plan; the area was zoned 'single-family.' Moreover, as the citizens learned along the way, the city's existing mitigation fees would have created a substantial shortfall for the school district's capital facilities.

³ It's interesting, if not altogether tragic, to consider the mischief caused against the new owners of the Davis House, which used to be called the town's Opera House. Adhering rigidly to the code, city planners prevented the owners, who live on the top floor of the structure, from building a bathroom more convenient to their sleeping quarters. So, the owners must walk the equivalent of a half-block to do what humans must do

from time to time.

⁴ Benfield, Raimi, and Chen: *Once There were Greenfields: How Urban Sprawl is Undermining America's Environment, Economy and Social Fabric* (1999)

⁵ Marysville's mayor has demonstrated his true colors in the past. He vetoed the unexpected 1993 action of the city council to modestly raise school impact mitigation fees. For this, the mayor earned poster-child recognition from the iniquitous Master Builders Association, the enemy of all things good and wholesome.

⁶ *Barren boomerang* is a term that I coined several years ago to describe Marysville's new "town center." In its layout, the mall is L-shaped and therefore resembles the outline of a boomerang. It has rarely been fully occupied, and over its brief history has been in receivership several times. Thus, like a boomerang, the mall keeps coming back as a reminder to the city of its councils' foresight and stretched imagination.



WHAT WOULD AN ATTRACTIVE, VIABLE DOWNTOWN LOOK LIKE?

There have been many books and articles written about the impacts of sprawl and what to do about it, including how to revitalize, improve, or create a downtown. Here are just a few that I have read:

Suburban Nation: The Rise of Sprawl and the Decline of the American Dream, by Andres Duany, Elizabeth Plater-Zyberk, and Jeff Speck (2000)

The Next American Metropolis: Ecology, Community, and the American Dream, by Peter Calthorpe (1993)

Once There Were Greenfields: How Urban Sprawl is Undermining America's Environment, Economy and Social Fabric, by F. Kaid Benfield, Matthew D. Raimi, and Donald D.T. Chen (1999)

The New Urbanism: Toward an Architecture of Community, by Peter Katz (1994)

Alternatives to Sprawl, by Dwight Young (1995)

Cities Back from the Edge: New Life for Downtown, by Roberta Brandes Gratz (1998)

These books describe the negative effects of sprawl (are there any that are positive?), and most, but notably Calthorpe's, offer some specific, practical ideas on what can be done to arrest sprawl's centrifugal forces. A common theme is to establish a viable, vital, attractive urban core that is above all pedestrian-friendly. Let's

focus on Calthorpe's prescriptions here.

In the book that I've referenced above, Peter Calthorpe, an architect and Berkeley professor, provides what I might call "town-transforming for dummies." By that I don't mean to belittle Calthorpe's considerable accomplishments. On the contrary, his book serves as an accessible and practical guide for city planners, architects, traffic engineers, developers, and the rest of us interested in creating environmentally sound communities. I draw particular attention to his chapter "Design Guidelines." It's important, I think, to walk through these pages.

TRANSIT-ORIENTED DEVELOPMENT (TOD)

New Urbanists, especially, feature alternative modes of transportation within their projects. Calthorpe exemplifies this approach. Whether writing about trains, busses, or bicycles, Calthorpe urges all of us to get out of our cars.

To make this work, towns must be more compact than the typical sprawling suburb like Marysville or Lynnwood. Calthorpe offers the following definition of a TOD:

A Transit-Oriented Development is a mixed-use community within an average 2,000-foot walking distance of a transit stop

and core commercial area. TODs mix residential, retail, office, open space, and public uses in a walkable environment, making it convenient for residents and employees to travel by transit, bicycle, foot, or car.

Readers will immediately note that there are no TODs within Snohomish County. So, we can only imagine what they might look like, using Calthorpe as a guide.

Those few who do walk amidst the jungle of motor vehicles look as if they're behind in their medicines.

In Marysville, the Burlington Northern train tracks run through the heart of what was once a vital downtown; Amtrak takes passengers from Seattle to

Vancouver, B.C. There used to be a depot located adjacent to the site now occupied by Burger King. A half-block further to the north, opposite Comeford Park, a new depot could be built to serve a TOD. It would replace the building currently used by the Flapjack Restaurant, the offices of the Marysville Education Association, and a car repair shop.

A commercial core would be built around the depot and along a portion of Comeford Park's perimeter. Calthorpe would include "offices, community-serving retail centers, and moderate-to high-density housing." How dense? Calthorpe suggests 26 dwelling units per acre at the high end and 10 du/ac at the low.

Marysville's density in the "downtown" area is 2.5 units per acre. However, the current comprehensive plan projects only 2.1 dwelling units per acre for downtown in the year 2012. Beyond the initial commercial core, Calthorpe would place single-family dwellings, albeit not on the large lots to which most suburban dwellers are accustomed.

Calthorpe heavily emphasizes the public realm and seeks in his projects to include parks, plazas, open space ("greens"), and public buildings. The depot I have in mind would open to Marysville's original town plaza, Comeford Park. It fills a bit more than two and one-half acres with large stretches of lawn, a gazebo used for performances, a playground for children, and the community center, which formerly housed city hall.

SIDEWALKS

Most of us—and for good reason—fail to grasp that streets have the potential for being critical parts of the public realm. There are very few streets in Snohomish County that engender a sense of place or enclosure. Most streets are designed for vehicles and that's how they look, with large asphalt expanses, paint striping, and narrow—or nonexistent—sidewalks, on which few travel. People really have to drive their vehicles (mostly SUVs and pickups) everywhere. Those few who do walk amidst the jungle of motor vehicles look as if they're behind in their medicines.

The great streets of the world, found mostly in Europe, feature

extremely wide sidewalks (greater than 25 feet), large trees along the curbs that provide natural shade, public benches, and canopied storefronts abutting the walkways. These streets are designed to accommodate *people* as well as cars. And people flock there to be around one another, to talk, to shop, and to visit.

In addition to being much wider than they are in Marysville and other towns, sidewalks should be more carefully and attractively integrated with both adjacent buildings and roadways. Someone daring to walk in "downtown" Marysville will find it awkward if not dangerous. Streets are designed by engineers to ensure traffic flows and not pedestrian safety. So, a pedestrian has very little protection from two-ton SUVs. In stepping off the curb, the pedestrian is made to feel as if he or she is interfering with the vehicles, whose drivers understandably assume that the streets are made for them.

PLACES TO SIT

Have you ever noticed how few benches or chairs are available for people to take a break and relax from walking about the town?



Parisian street scene

by Allan B. Jacobs

We're all very busy, you know. We have so much to do and so little time to enjoy the scenery. In Marysville it's actually against the law to sit on a downtown sidewalk. If one got tired after shopping at the barren boomerang (with so few functioning stores that's not likely, but indulge me), one could always lie down in the huge asphalt lagoon. There's plenty of room, but make sure there are no police around.

TREES

Can there ever be too many trees? Perhaps. But we residents of Snohomish County may never know.

Different trees serve different purposes. Those that align wide sidewalks should have fairly tall limb-free trunks so that pedestrians don't suffer head trauma. And their foliage should be full and spread out into the street as well as the sidewalk so as to form a natural canopy.

STOREFRONTS

If you've ever walked along a pleasant urban street you may have noticed that the storefronts abut the sidewalk; they are not set back behind asphalt lagoons. The store owners also value pedestrians peering inside to glance at their merchandise. So the stores have *windows*. Also, most storefronts on nice streets have cloth or permanent canopies that help protect pedestrians from the weather.

MIXED-USE

Not everyone in our society can afford to buy a single-family home. In Seattle, the median-priced home is approaching \$250,000. But household incomes are just above \$50,000, far below what's required to qualify for the house. Yet renting need not be the ugly, pitiful experience that most developers and city

planners create.

In a vibrant, viable downtown, public-minded developers, supported by wise city planners, erect multi-story buildings that include a mix of retail, office, and residential space. This combination allows for affordable apartment units to serve both young and old—those who desire proximity to more urban amenities.

RESTAURANTS

People who live in or frequent downtowns want places to eat. Paris cafés open out to the sidewalk, where proprietors locate tables and chairs that can be freely arranged by patrons as they wish. On a few Seattle streets, one can experience a pleasant meal or cup of coffee out in the public realm, just in front of the restaurant or coffee house. In Marysville and other Snohomish County venues, however, the sidewalks are too narrow and the scenery too unwelcoming to beckon any reasonable person outdoors for a languorous, conversational lunch.

But whether one desires to eat indoors or outside, the opportunities are severely limited. And in most instances, people don't just stop in after a few hours of shopping or a morning at the library. Rather, they drive to the restaurant, which is likely to be in a strip mall. There are few downtown restaurants, because, to overstate the obvious, there are few downtowns.

THE PUBLIC SPHERE

Our society has become increasingly disenchanted with the public realm. Nearly half of us don't bother to vote. We denigrate public officials. With proliferating initiatives, we threaten to convert consequential issues into plebiscites, and thereby circumvent representative democracy altogether. Worst of all, we are rapidly becoming a nation of self-satis-



South wall of barren boomerang—no windows

Site of old Donato's Building

fied idiots, having discarded "we" and "us" from our vocabularies. "What's in it for me?" has replaced "How can we help?"

We worship our private little gardens and our postage-stamp lawns as we rail against taxes that could be pooled for the collective benefit of all. Thus, our towns and cities feature very few parks, which are usually "donations" from the same developers who pillage the countryside, and none has public gathering places open freely to all.

Why doesn't it occur to people that they could gain so much more of the things that really matter by combining small contributions from everyone? Think of the public places we could collectively create if we abstained from the apparent need for so much private space.

Compounding the absence of common places, Marysville (which is not alone) has managed to broadly scatter its few public facilities about the city. The library, a rare gem and heavily used, is far removed from downtown and city hall. Busses no longer serve it, so most people have to use their car. The city offices are located in the old library. Meetings of the council and planning commission occur further down the road in the Public Safety Building, which also houses the fire and police depart-

ments. The post office is in the middle of a block on State Ave.

A city or town's public buildings should be prominently and centrally located, and should, themselves, be prominently designed and carefully constructed. Instead, places like Marysville locate city hall in the midst of residential units and set it back yards from the public street. The message is clear: out of sight, out of mind.

There is a photograph in the book *A Pattern Language* that depicts a group of nattily attired, earnest Londoners engaged in what appears to be a serious discussion of religion. One of them is standing atop a podium gesturing strongly. Attached to the front of the podium is a banner that reads "Protestant Alliance of London." A member of the "audience," with his mouth open, is pointing his finger at the speaker, suggesting that he is sharply disagreeing with what he's hearing. The others surrounding the speaker seem to be listening intently to the exchange.

The towns and cities of Snohomish County have no such public places where people can gather to debate or even to chat. Rather, if we bump into one another at all it is in the privately owned aisles of Albertson's or the parking lot of Fred Meyer. Usually we are shopping for this or that.

In short, there is no *center* that supports people coming together for anything other than shopping. Commerce has replaced conversation.

ART

Any serious effort to build a viable and vibrant downtown must include a significant budget for public art. We have become a nation of aesthetically deprived curs. In our heavily mechanistic world, the arts just don't fit. Look

around. Try to find beauty in the physical landscape. There is nothing but pervasive and unending ugliness. And why should we expect aesthetics in our downtowns when the most prominent feature of our homes is a garage door?

Calthorpe mentions "street vistas." Imagine looking west along Third St. in Marysville to see a beautiful fountain or clock tower rather than the oversized flag pole that now exists in front of Albertson's. Fountains, monoliths, or clocks "help orient pedestrians and make walking routes interesting and memorable," says Calthorpe.

A concern for attractive design should infuse all of downtown, from the materials used in sidewalks and street-crossings to the type of street lamps and public benches. Nor should city officials allow public buildings, in particular city hall, to reflect the workmanship of a typical split-level home built in the Northwest. Rather, these buildings should serve as significant monuments to the public realm.

INTEGRATION AND A MASTER PLAN

All of these and other elements must be carefully integrated to achieve a downtown that works. If we are to live closer together, we must do so in a manner that attracts rather than repels, with careful attention to the public realm. Downtowns cannot be just commercial centers like the new Redmond Town Center, where attempts to provide an experience of community seem so false and contrived. Nor can we expect more from merely centralizing public buildings. A viable downtown requires an intelligent mix of residential units, commercial and retail space, restaurants,



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An investment in the future

entertainment facilities, public gathering places, attractive streets, and abundant landscaping—all within easy walking distance.

Above all, any attempt to revitalize downtown requires the active participation and support of the citizenry. After all, downtown—if it is to be successful—must primarily serve the local population.

Revitalization, then, should begin with a collective visioning process (what architects and urban designers call 'charrettes'), in which the townspeople gather to share their ideas. Ideally, those ideas converge in the competent hands of an architect or urban designer in the form of a master plan, preferably illustrated in three dimensions. If people are to give their moral and financial support to the major task of revitalizing their downtown, they must be able to "see" what it will look like. They have to gain some visual appreciation for how the various elements come together.

WHERE TO BEGIN

The simplest and most straightforward way to launch a revitalization effort is through the action of a bright, civic-minded city council. The action would be two-fold: (1) establish a committee of citizens; and (2) provide the committee with a clear charter

and adequate resources.

Unfortunately, most of our city governments operate as tools of the housing industry, which has heavily funded the campaigns of council members. Developers, builders, and real estate officials typically think short term and exploit local governments to enhance their profit margins. Thus, the citizens' first task is to elect progressive, environmentally conscious people to represent the interests of the entire community, both present and future.

Moreover, even if they are not beholden to the housing industry, many elected officials have a very difficult time thinking beyond the next sewer line or the end of their nose. They become mired in the trivial details of utility matters, zoning issues, and land-use issues. Rarely do they abstract up or imagine possibilities.

The responsibility for stimulating people's collective imaginations ultimately lies with the people themselves. Necessarily the effort begins with small steps, including the reading of the many new books being written on sprawl and its alternatives. Through diligence, ideas will ripple through the body politic.

But focus on the center.

IF YOU LIKE GROWTH FOR GROWTH'S SAKE, YOU'LL LOVE THE EDC

Touting itself as the state's "oldest Economic Development Corporation in Washington," the Snohomish County EDC hired a consultant (R & M Resource Development) to assess the feasibility of the agency's spending nearly a million dollars a year. The goal: "strengthen the existing job base within the County, and put in place a unified, countywide, proactive economic development initiative to market our County and attract new capital investment." The consultant's report concludes that, with a few minor changes in the EDC, the goal is both sound and necessary.

Snohomish County has not been fertile territory for investors. Jobs have lagged behind population growth. We have become famous for roadway congestion, on the one hand, and low-density sprawl, on the other. This unhappy combination has been exacerbated by an inadequate telecommunications infrastructure.

Compared with their counterparts to the south, Snohomish County residents are poorer and less educated. People come here for the cheap housing and little else. With limited spending power and tastes that run to Slurpees and Wal-Mart, we lack the more favorable demographics of Kirkland,

Redmond, and now, it seems, even Tacoma (which is undergoing an economic and, some say, cultural revival spurred principally by the municipal utility's robust and cheap telecommunications infrastructure). And even if the likes of Intel or a batch of dot-coms were to invade the county, there is no local college or university to supply local talent. The electrical engineers and code warriors, used to attracting huge signing bonuses and generous stock options, would likely prefer to live and work in areas where people do more with their time than mow the lawn and go to church.

But the EDC, the Who's Who of local moneyed interests desperate to join the capitalist caravan, believes, in the consultant's words, that it's time to "create a diversified 21st Century economy that will attract the high growth, high wage, technology business, manufacturing, and other clusters of growth to enhance the quality of life for the citizens [read 'the local well-heeled elite'] of Snohomish County."

The cornerstone of this effort is marketing. Half the total recommended budget of \$3.5 million would be spent on selling the county, enticing willing external investors, and "target[ing] industries to produce higher salaried jobs at the median family income level." (The target is 4,000 new jobs paying between \$38,000 and \$45,000 a year.) The consultants recommend that the EDC "promote Snohomish County's

strengths and broadcast them." That's a big challenge. It's not as if investors lack maps. Nor has the county been trying to hide itself all these years. Boosterism remains an energetic yet largely humiliating activity: the more people talk about the county, the less folks want to listen. After Boeing, what is there left to say?

Aside from the horrifying fact that the county has an abysmal record of commercial diversity (airplane-building, creating a home for navy boats, and fast food restaurants), and that its "growth" has been anything but environmentally benign, imagine the evil that would emerge from mixing economic development of the kind envisaged by the EDC with the prosaic, narrow-mindedness of the housing industry.

The EDC and its consultants would love to plaster the countryside with sprawling campus-like business centers fed by miles of new asphalt. Roads couldn't be built fast enough nor wide enough to accommodate the swell of SUVs. Dwayne Lane's derriere would be blistered from so many horse-riding commercials. A trip down I-5 from Marysville to Smokey Point might take a week. Ah, but the homebuilders would be busier and richer than ever, constructing tract after tract of mind-numbing crap.

Snohomish County has given the world a splendid example of how to do things wrong: build,

raze, destroy, build, congest, destroy, raze, build, sprawl...without a whit of concern for aesthetics, common sense, efficiency, and the environment. We have become very good at indiscriminately scattering offices, houses, schools, apartments, city halls, manufacturing centers, and fast food igloos throughout the county, then seemingly deriving a perverse delight in trying to connect the dots.

Against this pitiful backdrop, think for a moment about the ensuing contest between cities for the investment capital recruited by the EDC. With one or two exceptions, all mayors behave like Marysville's. They want growth and more growth. Above all, they want "jobs" for the thousands of people who merely live and shop within their respective jurisdictions. So, what will Marysville offer? How about Monroe, or Arlington, or Lake Stevens? Tax incentives? Miniscule, even non-existent stream buffers? A brand new sewer facility paid for by homeowners? Negative impact fees? What am I bid? This unhealthy and ultimately unworkable competition between cities is good for those being courted but lousy for the people inhabiting these various burgs—both the "winners" and the "losers."